the death of a Taliban defector. It turned out the man they named had been killed two years earlier. But as soon as the first criticism arrived, the *Guardian* reporters began to panic.

With hindsight, I can't fault the *Guardian* for the initial work they did in making the documents ready. It was an excellent job, done in the best traditions of their paper, and I felt that some of them – Ian Katz, the deputy editor, and Harold Frayman, the systems editor – brought a level of normality and hard graft to the proceedings. The senior news reporter, of course, scuppered some of that easiness by telling me some of the workers on the *Guardian* had asked for 'danger money' because they were being followed. Over the years I had worked with journalists all over the world, but I had never before encountered a group with so little coolness in the face of threat, so little confidence in the manner of working with people who weren't exactly like them, and so little evident experience in handling basic issues of security. When Alan Rusbridger called Bill Keller to ask if he knew how to set up a secure telephone line, the New Yorker was not fit for purpose. He had no idea. And despite the efforts of some of their respective staffs to enjoy the moment and make the collaboration work at all costs, there were others, the twelve angry men, who were embroiled at every turn in their own careerist dramas, which naturally turned on me as the supposed figurehead of the operation.

I felt I had a clear strategy in going with the Afghan war logs first and following with those from Iraq. The Afghan stuff was less voluminous, and I wanted to see if we – meaning WikiLeaks in collaboration with the media partners – could set up systems for reading and publishing the data, training the journalists and graphics people in how to do it before bringing that experience to the more complicated job of dealing with the hundreds of thousands of documents from Iraq. The two main papers, as I said, had asked for the Iraq material as a 'sweetener': they had gone after it with almost sinister levels of zeal, which caused me to think they would go all-out and make a good job of unwrapping the cache for the public. I can be mono-minded and fixed on an objective, so I was sure the next big push would be happening over the following three weeks. What I hadn't factored into the thing was a high level of journalistic ennui: Iraq wasn't as 'sexy' as Afghanistan, a present and ongoing war. I had thought the various staff would do a better job on the Iraq material, having learned how to do it, but they were burnt out, and many of them went on holiday immediately. You